

Pynchon Character Etymology: Étienne Cherdlu

Cite as: Martin Paul Eve, "Pynchon Character Etymology: Étienne Cherdlu", *eve.gd: Martin Paul Eve*, January 09, 2012, <https://doi.org/10.59348/6h72y-0n357>.

With thanks to Roland Clare, a quick snippet of interest (certainly to me, anyway) on the etymology of a certain Étienne Cherdlu, a character featuring, despite omission from Hurley's *Pynchon Character Names: A Dictionary* (Hurley, Patrick. Pynchon Character Names: A Dictionary. Jefferson N.C.: McFarland & Co. Publishers, 2008.), in "The Secret Integration". (Pynchon, Thomas. "The Secret Integration." In *Slow Learner: Early Stories*, 139-193. Boston: Back Bay Books/Little Brown, 1985.)

The name is a reference to ETAOIN SHRDLU, a phrase that appeared during the days of linotype machines where keys were arranged by letter frequency in the English language. ETAOINSHRDLU are, then, the key orders, similar to qazwsx on a contemporary keyboard.

 Linotype

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